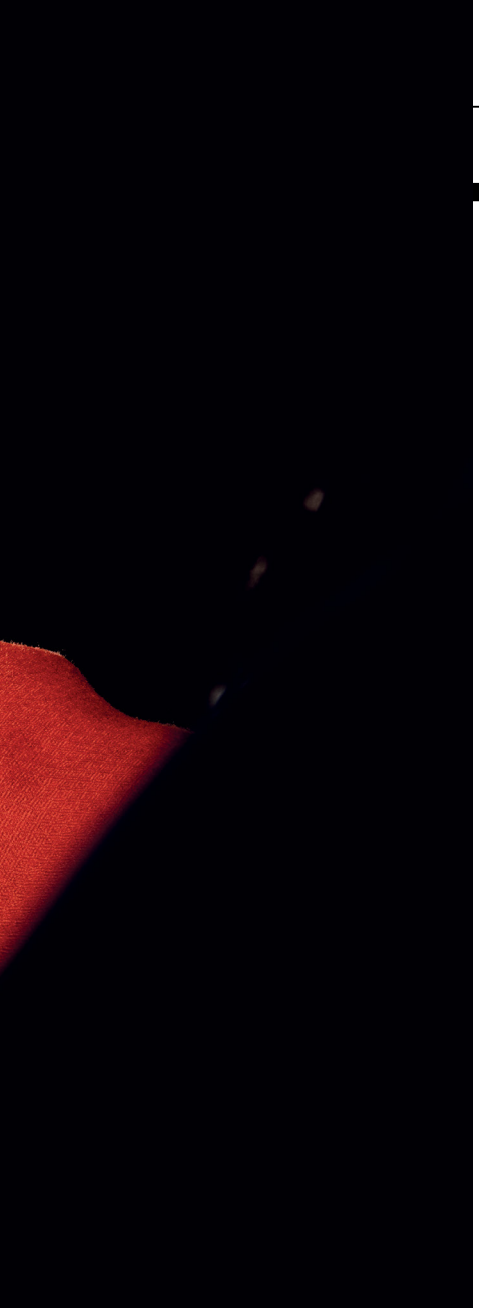


Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

working on six currently. [As regards] airport connectivity, when we came to power, UP had only two functional airports—Lucknow and Varanasi; Gorakhpur would see an occasional flight. Today, UP has nine functional airports. Asia's biggest airport is being built at Jewar. Another airport is being constructed at Ayodhya.

Q. What about welfare schemes for the poor?
Regarding welfare schemes for the poor, in the five years before 2017, Akhilesh Yadav had only sanctioned 18,000 houses and not handed over even a single one. Our government has given a house each to 43 lakh poor families. We have made a toilet available to each of the 2.61 crore poor families in the state. When we came to power in 2017, 1,21,000 hamlets had never seen electricity, we began electrification works there and then gave free connections to 1.47 crore families. We provided free LPG connections to 1.56 crore families. When we came to power, people were dying of hunger in the state. Today, we are playing a leading role in terms of the Public Distribution System. Fifteen crore people are getting free ration. The farmer was dying of suicide before 2017. We came to power, waived farmers' loans. The SP-BSP ruled for 14 years, and what they couldn't pay cane farmers in this time, we managed to do in five years. Our government has so far paid Rs 1.55 lakh crore worth of cane dues.

> **"In the past 70 years, only one and a half expressways had been built in the state. We are working on six currently. In 2016, UP had two airports, now there are nine"**

Q. But why did farmers descend here in protest?
No farmers came here, there were no demonstrations here. They came here in support of the three farm laws. The Bharatiya Kisan Union initially supported the three farm bills but when the Sanyukta Kisan Morcha was formed and Punjab and Haryana farmers staged a *dharna*, they joined them. Otherwise, they had supported the laws. That is why there was no law and order problem in UP despite the complete anarchy in neighbouring states. Why, the BJP even ended up winning by-elections and Panchayat elections with thumping majorities.

Q. What about the incident in Lakhimpur Kheri...
That was not a farmers' agitation. That was a confrontation between two sides and an unfortunate incident...and the state took all the necessary action as per the law. Now, the Supreme Court is monitoring all the proceedings. An SIT and a judicial commission have been formed to look into the matter. Whatever the state had to do, it did based on the merits of the case and in accordance with the law.

Q. The Congress general secretary in charge of UP, Priyanka Gandhi, has given 40 per cent of seats to women. Why is the BJP not doing the same?
The BJP is giving tickets to applicants on merit. The maximum number of women MLAs and MPs are from the BJP. We do not believe in just giving them tickets but also in ensuring their success and helping them earn respectability. For us, the Mission Shakti programme is linked to respect for women, their safety and self-reliance. It is not a part of the political agenda. It is linked to their honour and empowerment.

Q. A couple of OBC ministers have left your cabinet in the recent past, with one of them alleging that you didn't even allow him to look at files.
If someone has been clever, then it's time to take leave, chapter closed! What I am saying is that the public knows the truth. We had on the very first day decided that we would have zero tolerance towards crime and criminals as well as corruption and the corrupt. Had this policy not informed all our actions, the government would not have been able to face the electorate with this image and enthusiasm. We would not have been able to fulfil our promise of changing the perception of